# Bums (Evelyn, aka Mary)

## By Robert Shaffron *(cutting revised and expanded, 2026)*

*Lights up on Evelyn (aka Mary). She is absolutely still and looks out directly into the audience. She speaks as Evelyn, the woman Mary was before going mad. Rational, a little shy.*

**MARY:** **(Pg 112)** I don't know when I stopped living my life and my life started living me. *(beat)* My mother was a Christian. A Bible slamming, fire and brimstone, hallelujah Christian. I remember the day — the night — of her conversion. I was sleeping. She tore into the apartment — I slept on the couch — and she was out of breath, and her hair was, well, some of it had slipped out from under the elastic band she always had it pulled back in. And she ran around the room turning on all the lamps, and she turned on the light in the little half-kitchen, and she turned on the lights in her bedroom and left the door open so the light came into the living room where I was sleeping. I sat up, I was scratching and trying to straighten the crumpled sheets under me with my eyes closed the lights were so bright and I asked her, "Ma why are you turning all the lights on like that it hurts my eyes." And she rushed over to me and she pulled me off the couch onto the floor and said, "Evelyn, we're gonna get down on our knees and pray. In the light. And we're gonna pray to the Lord that we may always live in the light. The clean, pure holy light that falls down on us from the good Lord in heaven." We'd never prayed in our lives. I didn't even know what praying was, really. I knew people prayed in church. I'd seen pictures of churches, and they always looked beautiful and scary with the colored lights all coming through the stained glass windows and shiny wood benches and gigantic stone arches, and I wondered how in hell we were gonna pray in our little apartment with the greasy walls and the chipped tile floors and bare lightbulbs — scary but not beautiful like the churches. *(beat)* All Mother wanted was a man who wouldn't leave her so she brought God home. And he stayed. Mother went crazy with religion. And as soon as I was old enough, I did the only thing I could think to do. I got pregnant and left home. Amen

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## INTRODUCTION

*This is Evelyn Kantmeier's story. Evelyn Kantmeier, also known as Mary.*

*But before Mary shatters the silence with fragmented faith and fury, it's important to ground her story in the stark reality faced by many in the United States today.* * *On a single night in 2024, over 770,000 people were experiencing homelessness, the highest count on record, with roughly 36% of them living unsheltered on the streets, in cars, or in encampments rather than in shelters.* ** *Within this population, mental illness looms large: about 22–26% of homeless adults are living with a serious mental illness. And broader research estimates that up to two-thirds of unhoused individuals have a current mental health disorder when substance use and mood disorders are included.*

*These numbers remind us that Evelyn's unraveling isn't just personal tragedy. It reflects a broader crisis of displacement, invisibility, and unmet care that haunts communities across the nation.*

*Bums by Robert Shaffron*

*MARY is on the stage writing furiously in the margins of a discarded newspaper. She is overweight, slovenly, looks to be in her 50s but may be younger. Next to her is a fold-away shopping cart with a variety of objects: bags, clothing, a thermos, newspapers, etc. She suddenly stops writing, and looks up at the audience, suspicious.*

**MARY:** **(Pg 103-104)** Whattaya lookin' at? Whattaya lookin' at?? Bastids always lookin', lookin' — wanna see what I'm writin' here. Always lookin' at me outa the sides o' their eyes so they think I don't know they're lookin'. Know what I'm writin' here? I'm writin' the Bible. That's right. Ya read the Bible, ain't ya? Well, I wrote it. Only it ain't finished. I gotta finish it. Sometimes I ain't got enough paper and I gotta write it on the *New York Newsday.* Only first I gotta cross out all the words that's already printed there so nobody gets the Bible mixed up with the *New York Newsday.*

*(an outburst) HEY YOU TRYIN' TO LOOK UP MY DRESS?! I KNOW WHAT YOU WAS LOOKIN' AT! YOU JUST GET YOUR EYES OUTTA THERE AIN'T NOTHIN' UP THERE YOU GOT NO BUSINESS GOOGLIN' AT! I KNOW WHAT YOU WAS TRYIN' TO LOOK AT SNEAKIN' PEEKS UP MY DRESS WHILE I'M WRITIN' THE HOLY WORD!!*

*(a beat, then back to normal tone.)* You know why I'm writin' the Bible? You know why? God tol' me to. God the little infant Jesus tol' me to. You know why he picked me? He knows the

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evil I seen. That's right. I seen the worst evil in the world and the Holy Lord our savior Jesus Christ tells me the word and he writes the Holy Epistle through me. I'm a vessel. I'm a vessel of the Lord. You wanna know my name? I'll tell ya. It's Mary. That's all. Nothin' else. Just Mary. Used to be Evelyn Kantmeier. Now it's Mary.

**(Pg 106-108)** *(rummaging through one of her bags)* Whattaya lookin' at?? Wanna see what's in my bag, doncha? Everybody does. Everybody wants to see. Wanna know? Wanna see what's in here? You'll rot in hell first. Nobody gets in my bag. It's my bag. It's fulla my treasures. Man touched my bag once. He's sorry. I was sittin' in Grand Central Station I like it there you can feel the Lord's presence in the echoes. I'm sittin' there writin' the Bible with my special bag down between my feet I keep the handle wrapped around my leg so no stinkin' bastid can steal it 'cause everybody wants it. Wants to possess it it's precious. I'm sittin' right on that bench writin' and keepin' an eye out for evil — I'm the Holy Lord's guardian of evil. I keep an eye out when God is watchin' over things over in Italy or somethin' — bastid comes up tries to touch my bag. Musta been crazy is the only thing I can figure. But I got him. Fixed the crazy son of a b**** good. Put a curse on him. Ordained his hands to fall off. He'll never touch another bag again. Eye for an eye. I wrote that.

*(beat)* Don't touch my bag. You don't ever touch my bag. Thou shalt not lay a rotten finger on my bag and that's a commandment. *(beat)* You wanna know what's in my bag? Sacraments. Holy sacraments and treasures and some sacred relics. And some cigarettes. *(beat)* Alright. I'll show ya. But only if you swear on the holy mother's eyes not to covet nothin' in here. But you will. You'll covet it all. It's holy. *(pulls out an old cardigan sweater with pearls or sequins on it. It's wrinkled and dirty)* Here. This here's sacred vestments. Jesus wore this at the Last Supper. Then he gave it to me. Isn't it beautiful? *(shakes it so the sequins catch the ligh.)* It glows. That's holy light. You wanna touch it? It heals. *(holds it out, then snatches it back)* Don't even try.

*(rummages in the bag and finds a keychain with keys on it; shakes it)* This here's Jesus' lucky keychain. He blessed this. Sometimes it spouts wine. *(goes back into the bag, pulls out a*

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*crumpled box of Count Chocula cereal)* This is the holy communion. This box got the wafers that's the flesh of Christ. *(opens the box, places a single piece of cereal on her tongue)* Ain't supposed to chew it. Gotta let it lie on your tongue and count your sins while it melts. *(takes a handful of cereal and eats it.)* Only I ain't got no sins. I been purified. 'Sgot marshmallows in it. *(rummages in the bag again, pulling out a succession of objects, until she comes up with a tattered baby doll)* This is Him. This is the Holy Infant Jesus himself. Not Him. His image. The Baby Jesus. My beautiful, blessed Baby Jesus. This here's loaded with holy magic spiritual power. No one, ***no one*** can ever hold this Infant Jesus. 'Cept me. One little touch and he'll resurrect and smite you but good.

**(Pg 116-118)** *(suddenly angry)* Whattaya think I'm a goddamn freak show??! Don't look at me. I was in the convent for a long time. But I escaped. The religious persecution of Sister Mary *(hysterical laugh, then stops abruptly)* They refused to call me by my chosen holy name. Called me Evelyn. *(mimicking)* Evelyn, DEAR, don't you want to sit in the music area with the other ladies? Evelyn, DEAR, wouldn't you like something to eat? *(back to her own voice)* Food there was rotten. Lousy convent. *(beat)* I took the holy communion every day. Twice a day. They brought it to me in my cell. Barged right in with their communion trolley. Kept the wafers in little white paper cups to keep the holiness from leaking out.

I was in the convent 'cause of the evil I seen. I seen a woman. A terrible, cruel woman. With a child. A little boy. They was in the playground in the park. Swing mommy swing, said the little boy. The woman picked him up and held him under his tiny thin arms, and put him on the swing, all dressed in the blue romper she sewed for him herself. (*gets the doll out of her bag and mimes the story with the doll)*

It was a beautiful day that day. The sun was so bright and loud, louder than all the evil in the world. So loud it shut out all the evil. Swing mommy swing. So gently she pushed him in the swing. Higher mommy higher. The sun was so bright, the light was so beautiful. She pushed harder. A little harder. He swung farther away. Higher mommy higher. He laughed. She

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loved the sound of his laugh. It was magic how she pushed him and he flew away and back, away and back. Laughing, screaming with joy as he flew up into the light.

*(by now she is on her knees, clutching the doll to her breast and rocking with it)* MY BABY! JESUS MY JESUS GOD MY BABY WHERE IS MY BABY!!!!!

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Robert Shaffron***
***Book: Off-Off Broadway Festival Plays, 14th Series; Pgs 101-121***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2001 National Qualifier***
***2002 National Qualifier***
***2003 National Qualifier***
***2004 National Qualifier***
***2005 National Qualifier***
***2006 National Qualifier***
***2007 National Qualifier***
***2008 National Qualifier***
***2009 National Qualifier***
***2010 National Qualifier***
***2012 National Qualifier***
***2013 National Qualifier***
***2014 National Qualifier***
***2016 National Qualifier***
***2016 National Qualifier – MS***
***2017 National Qualifier***
***2018 National Qualifier***
***2020 National Qualifier***
***2021 National Qualifier***
***2021 National Qualifier – MS***
***2022 National Qualifier – MS***
***2023 National Qualifier***
***2024 National Qualifier***
***2025 National Qualifier***
***NIETOC***
***CA State Qualifier***
***CO State Qualifier***
***IL State Qualifier***
***IN State Qualifier***
***OH State Qualifier***

***Source information for Introduction***

* *https://www.reuters.com/world/us/trump-orders-crackdown-homeless-encampments-nationwide-2025-07-25/*

** *https://www.kff.org/mental-health/a-look-at-the-new-executive-order-and-the-intersection-of-homelessness-and-mental-illness/*

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